

If character is not taught, how can it possibly be learned? The affluent world in which so many young citizens exist today doesn't easily create the ability to build character. Often character requires failure; it requires adversity; it requires contemplation; it requires determination and steadfastness; it requires finding one's own space as an individual. And it surely requires honor. Yet we rarely seem to emphasize character, even though in our society today there are priceless sources of inspiration right at hand. In fact, the challenge isn't finding useful sources of inspiration, but sorting out the very good from the best. While the Old Testament, for example, may not use the word *character*, it describes character beautifully in these words:

What is man that you are mindful of him, the son of man that you care for him? Psalms 8:4

The fear of the Lord teaches a man wisdom, and humility comes before honor. Proverbs 15:33

Humility and the fear of the Lord bring wealth and honor and life. Proverbs 22:4

He who pursues righteousness and love finds life, prosperity and honor. Proverbs 21:21

The New Testament is rich with sources as well. Recall, for example, St. Paul's warning, "They that will be rich fall into temptation and a snare and into many foolish and hurtful lusts, which drown men in destruction and perdition. For the love of money is the root of all evil." Or St. Luke's demand of those who have been blessed with plenty (which, defined broadly, includes the substantial majority of us Americans today): "For unto whomsoever much is given, of him much shall be required.... And to whom men have committed much, of them they will ask the more."

William Shakespeare did his part, too, summing it all up so beautifully in these familiar words from *Hamlet*, profound words of advice that Polonius gives to his son, Laertes, as the young man is about to depart for France: